

Ethics Reflection

Just because I can access my classmate's files doesn't mean I should. Even if their permission settings made them accidentally public, opening those files would be ethically wrong in this context.

It doesn't really depend on what the files are. Looking at someone else's private documents, class notes, or personal files without permission is a violation of their privacy, even if I don't do anything bad with the information. This fits the idea of a "harmless wrong". The action is wrong not because it causes obvious damage, but because it disrespects their personal boundaries and violates the trust of the shared academic environment.

It also definitely depends on what I do with the information. If I just looked and closed the files, it's still a privacy violation. If I copied their work or shared their private info, that would make it much worse and could cause real harm.

The right thing to do is to tell my classmate about their permission mistake so they can fix it, not to take advantage of their error.

Ultimately, this scenario is a common test of integrity in digital spaces. The ease of access doesn't create a right to access. Upholding ethics means acting correctly even when no one is watching and there is no rule explicitly forbidding the action. In a university setting, where we are learning to be professionals, making the choice to protect a peer's privacy, even from their own mistake, is part of that learning. It reinforces that our community is built on trust and respect, not just on what the system permissions technically allow.